India than I do about the South, which is partly why I set myself the task of researching and writing this book, which concentrates on the country south of the Narmada, the river that takes its name from the Sanskrit for ‘Giver of Pleasure’, and which the British, for no reason that I can establish, called the Nerbudda.

The Narmada runs east to west along a rift in the Earth’s crust that forms a natural 800-mile ditch across the country. This, by ancient tradition, marks the divide between North and South India, and with good reason, since the Narmada is banked on both sides by mountain ranges: the Vindhyas to the north, the Satpuras on its south bank. In geological terms the Vindhyas and Satpuras are part of a whole, the so-called Vindhyan supergroup, made up of layer upon layer of loose rock strata piled one upon another. Taken together, the ditch and its palisades create a formidable barrier, and one that the early chroniclers of the Arya were quick to designate the southern limits of their primary homeland, drawing on a word from the Prakrit or common tongue, *Dakhina*, to name the unknown country beyond in their more refined Sanskrit *Dakshina*, the ‘south country’, subsequently smoothed out into the word Deccan.

In the days of the British Raj this country south of the Narmada River was widely known as the ‘sloth belt’, the idea being that it was a more provincial sort of place than the North, with its own slower pace of doing things, and so a social, cultural and political backwater which ambitious civil servants and military officers tried to avoid. It wasn’t, of course, but the tendency has always been to equate India with the North and to treat the South as an adjunct.

There is some justification for this, because before the supremacy of European sea-power India’s identity was largely shaped by waves of migrants emerging out of the mixing bowls of Eurasia by way of what is now Iran and Afghanistan. It meant that the political spotlight was always on the Indus, the river basin of the Punjab, and the Doab –